

wanted and justified to herself that she needed it, rather than plan ahead and save.

Beth found a Christian credit counseling service on the Internet and made an appointment to see someone in her area. She was determined to make a change in her life and sought a Christian service so she would do it according to God's principles.

Beth's first impression when she met with the coach, Jeri McFarland, was relief. Ms. McFarland assured her that her situation was not unique and was not impossible. From the time she said, "Hi, I'm Jeri," to the end of the first appointment, Beth knew she had an advocate.

Before the meeting, Jeri had asked Beth to write out all her debts, the monthly payments, the total due on each credit card, her auto payment, the student loans she was still paying on, her rent, utilities, and everything else. It wasn't a pleasant exercise, but Beth was now confident that God was on her side and had led her to this credit counseling service.

Jeri went over Beth's list of debts and asked her questions about her income. Beth was paid a salary and did not receive monetary bonuses, so she had a consistent paycheck twice a month. Jeri determined that Beth's situation qualified her for the program: she had debt she could not pay in full with her monthly income, but did have a steady income and intended to pay creditors all of what she owed.

Jeri contacted the creditors on Beth's behalf and worked out a payment plan each accepted. She negotiated a new interest rate with the credit card companies so new charges weren't accumulating.

Beth set up affordable, automatic payments each month to the credit counseling service, along with a modest fee, which it in turn paid out to each creditor. Beth's rent and car payment were not included in the plan—but she was not behind in her rent, and she contacted the company who held her auto loan herself and worked